Translation

How you, men of Athens, have been affected by my accusers, 17a
I do not know. For my part, I nearly forgot myself because of them, so persuasively did they speak. And yet they have said, so to speak, nothing true. I was most amazed by one of the many falsehoods they told, when they said that you should beware that you are not deceived by me, since I am a clever[1] speaker. They are not ashamed that they will immediately be b
refuted by me in deed, as soon as it becomes apparent that I am not a clever speaker at all; this seemed[2] to me to be most shameless of them, unless perhaps they call a clever speaker the one who speaks the truth. If this is what they are saying, then I too would agree that I am an orator—but not of their sort. These men, then, as I say, have said little or nothing true, while from me you will hear the whole truth—but by Zeus, men of Athens, not beautifully spoken speeches[3] like theirs, ordered and adorned[4] with phrases and words; rather, what you hear will be c
spoken at random[5] in the words that I happen upon—for I trust that the things I say are just—and let none of you expect otherwise. For surely it would not be becoming, men, for someone of my age to come before you fabricating[6] speeches like a youth. And, men of Athens, I do beg and beseech this of you: if you hear me speaking in my defense[7] with the same speeches I am accustomed to speak both in the market at the money-tables,[8] where many of you have heard me, and elsewhere, do not be amazed nor make a disturbance[9] because of this. For this is how d

17d it is: now is the first time I have come before a law court, at the age of seventy; hence I am simply[10] foreign to the manner of speech here. So just as, if I really[11] did happen to be a foreigner, you would surely sympathize with me if I spoke in that dialect[12] 18a and way in which I was raised, so I do beg this of you now (and it is just, as it seems to me): disregard the manner of my speech—for perhaps it may be worse, but perhaps better—and instead consider this very thing and apply your mind to this: whether the things I say are just or not. For this is the virtue[13] of a judge, while that of an orator is to speak the truth.

So first, men of Athens, it is just for me to speak in defense against the first false charges against me and the first accusers, and afterwards against the later charges and the later accusers. b For many have accused me to you, many years ago now, saying nothing true; and I fear them more than Anytus[14] and those with him, although they too are dangerous. But the others are more dangerous, men. They got hold of many of you from childhood, and they accused me and persuaded you—although it is no more true than the present charge—that there is a certain Socrates, a wise man,[15] a thinker[16] on the things aloft, who has investigated all things under the earth, and who makes the c weaker speech the stronger.[17] Those, men of Athens, who have scattered this report about, are my dangerous accusers. For their listeners hold that investigators of these things also do not believe in[18] gods. Besides, there are many of these accusers, and they have been accusing for a long time now. Moreover, they spoke to you at that age when you were most trusting, when some of you were children and youths, and they accused me in a case which simply went by default, for no one spoke in my defense. And the most unreasonable thing of all is that it is not d even possible to know and to say their names, unless one of them happens to be a comic poet.[19] Those who persuaded you by using envy and slander[20]—and those who persuaded others, after being convinced themselves—all of these are most difficult to get at. For it is also not possible to have any one of them come forward here and to refute him, but it is a necessity for me simply to speak in my defense as though fighting with shadows and refuting with no one to answer. So you, too, must deem it to be as I say: that there have been two groups of accusers, the

ones accusing me now, and the others long ago of whom I speak; and you must also suppose that I should first speak in defense against the latter, for you heard them accusing me earlier and much more than these later ones here. 18e

Well, then. A defense speech must be made, men of Athens, and an attempt must be made in this short time to take away your prejudice, which you got during a long time. I would wish it to turn out like this, if it were in any way better both for you and for me, and I would rather wish to accomplish something through my defense speech. But I suppose this is difficult, and I am not at all unaware of what sort of thing it is. Nevertheless, let this proceed in whatever way is dear to the god, but the law must be obeyed and a defense speech must be made. 19a

So let us take up from the beginning what the accusation is, from which has arisen the slander against me—which, in fact, is what Meletus[21] trusted in when he wrote this indictment against me. Well, then. What did the slanderers say to slander me? Their sworn statement, just as though they were accusers, must be read: "Socrates does injustice[22] and is meddlesome, by investigating the things under the earth and the heavenly things, and by making the weaker speech the stronger, and by teaching others these same things." It is something like this. For you yourselves also saw these things in the comedy of Aristophanes: a certain Socrates was borne about there, asserting that he was treading on air, and spouting much other drivel about which I comprehend nothing, either much or little.[23] And I do not say this to dishonor this sort of understanding,[24] if anyone is wise in such things (may I never be prosecuted with such indictments[25] by Meletus!); but I, men of Athens, have no share in these matters. Again, I offer the many[26] of you as witnesses, and I maintain that you should teach and tell each other, as many of you as have ever heard me conversing—and there are many such among you—tell each other, then, if any of you ever heard me conversing about such things, either much or little, and from this you will know that the same holds for the other things which the many say about me. b c d

But in fact none of these things is so; and if you have heard from anyone that I try to educate human beings[27] and that I charge money for it, that is not true either. Although this also e

19e seems to me to be noble,[28] if one is able to educate human beings, like Gorgias of Leontini, and Prodicus of Ceos, and Hippias of Elis.[29] For each of them, men, is able to go into each of the cities and persuade the young—who can associate with whomever of their own citizens they wish for free—they per-
20a suade these young men to leave off associating with the latter, and to associate with themselves instead, and to give them money and owe them thanks besides.

And for that matter, there is another man here, from Paros, a wise man, who I heard was in town; for I happened to go to a man who has paid more money to sophists than all the others, Callias, the son of Hipponicus.[30] So I questioned him (for he has two sons):

"Callias," I said, "If your two sons had been born colts or calves, we would have been able to get and pay a master for
b them who could make the two of them noble and good[31] in their appropriate virtue, and this man would have been from among those either skilled with horses or skilled in farming. But now, since they are two human beings, whom do you have in mind to get as a master[32] for the two of them? Who understands such virtue, that of human being and citizen? For I suppose you have considered it, since you possess sons. Is there someone," I said, "or not?"

"Certainly," he said.

"Who," I said, "and where is he from, and for how much does he teach?"

"Evenus," he said, "Socrates, from Paros: five minae."[33]

And I looked on Evenus as blessed if he should truly have this
c art[34] and teaches at such a modest rate. As for myself, I would plume[35] and pride myself on it, if I understood these things. But I do not understand them, men of Athens.

Perhaps, then, one of you might retort, "But, Socrates, what is it that you do?[36] Where have these slanders against you come from? For surely if you were practicing nothing more uncommon than others, such a report and account would not have arisen, unless you were doing something different from the
d many. Tell us what it is, then, so that we do not deal rashly with you."

In this, it seems to me, what the speaker says is just, and I will

try to demonstrate to you what it is that has brought me this name[37] and slander. So listen. And perhaps I will seem to some of you to be joking. Know well, however, that I will tell you the whole truth. For I, men of Athens, have gotten this name through nothing but a certain wisdom. What sort of wisdom, then, is this? Just what is perhaps human wisdom; for I am really likely to be wise in this. But those of whom I just spoke might perhaps be wise in some wisdom greater than human, or else I cannot say what it is. For I, at least, do not understand it, but whoever declares that I do lies and speaks in order to slander me. 20d e

Do not, men of Athens, make a disturbance against me, not even if I seem to you somehow to boast. For not mine is the story that I will tell,[38] but I will refer it to a speaker trustworthy to you. Of my wisdom, if indeed it is anything, and what sort of thing it is, I will offer for you as witness the god in Delphi. Now you know Chaerephon,[39] no doubt. He was my comrade from youth as well as a comrade of your multitude, and he shared in the recent exile[40] and returned with you. You do know what sort of man Chaerephon was, how vehement he was in whatever he would set out to do. Once he even went to Delphi and dared to consult the oracle about this—as I say, do not make a disturbance, men—he asked whether there is anyone wiser than I. The Pythia[41] replied that no one is wiser. Of these things his brother here will be a witness for you, since he himself has died. 21a

Now consider why I say these things; for I am going to teach you where the slander against me has come from. When I heard these things, I pondered them like this: "What ever is the god saying, and what riddle is he uttering? For I am aware that I am not at all wise, either much or little. So what is he saying when he asserts that I am wisest? Surely he is not saying something false; for that is not lawful[42] for him." And for a long time I was at a loss about what ever he was saying, but then very reluctantly I turned to something like the following investigation of it. b

I went to one of those reputed[43] to be wise, supposing that there, if anywhere, I would refute the divination[44] and show the oracle, "This man is wiser than I, but you declared that I was." So I considered this man thoroughly—I need not speak of him c

21c by name, but he was one of the politicians[45]—and when I considered him and conversed with him, men of Athens, I was affected something like this: it seemed to me that this man seemed to be wise, both to many other human beings and most of all to himself, but that he was not. And then I tried to show him that he supposed he was wise, but was not. So from this I
d became hateful both to him and to many of those present.

At any rate, as I went away, I reckoned with myself: "I am wiser than this human being. For neither of us is likely to know anything noble and good, but he supposes he knows something when he does not know, while I, just as I do not know, do not suppose I do. I *am* likely to be wiser than he in just this little something: that what I do not know, I do not suppose I know."

From there I went to someone else, one of those reputed to be
e wiser than that man, and these things seemed to me to be the same. And there I became hateful both to that man and to many others.

After this, then, I kept going to one after another, all the while perceiving with pain and fear that I was becoming hateful. Nevertheless, it seemed to be necessary to regard the matter of the god as most important. So I had to go, in seeking what the oracle was saying, to all those reputed to know something. And
22a by the dog,[46] men of Athens—for it is necessary to speak the truth before you—I was affected something like this: those with the best reputations seemed to me nearly the most deficient, in my investigation in accordance with the god, while others with more paltry reputations seemed to be men more fit in regard to prudence.[47]

Indeed, I must display to you how I wandered, as if performing certain labors,[48] so that the divination would become irrefutable for me. After the politicians I went to the poets of tragedies
b and dithyrambs, and the others, so that there I would catch myself in the act of being more ignorant than they. So I would take up those poems of theirs which it seemed to me they had worked on the most, and I would ask them thoroughly what they meant,[49] so that I might also learn something from them at the same time. I am ashamed to tell you the truth, men; nevertheless, it must be said. Almost all of those present, so to speak, would have spoken better than they did, about the poetry which

they themselves had made. So again, also concerning the poets, 22b
I quickly recognized that they did not make[50] what they made
by wisdom, but by a certain nature[51] and while inspired,[52] like c
the diviners and those who deliver oracles. For they also speak
many beautiful things, but they know nothing of what they
speak. It was apparent to me that the poets are also affected in
the same sort of way. At the same time, I perceived that they
supposed, on account of their poetry, that they were the wisest
of human beings also in the other things, in which they were
not. So I went away from there too supposing that I excelled
them in the very same thing in which I did the politicians.

Finally, then, I went to the manual artisans. For I was aware
that I understood nothing, so to speak, but I knew that I would d
discover that they understood many beautiful things. And I was
not wrong about this: they did understand things which I did
not understand, and in this way they were wiser than I. But,
men of Athens, the good craftsmen also seemed to me to make
the same mistake as the poets: because he performed his art
beautifully, each one deemed himself wisest also in the other
things, the greatest things—and this mistake of theirs seemed to
hide that wisdom. So I questioned myself on behalf of the ora- e
cle, whether I would prefer to be as I am, being in no way wise
in their wisdom nor ignorant in their ignorance, or to have both
things which they have. I answered myself and the oracle that it
profits me to remain just as I am.

Out of this examination, men of Athens, many hatreds have
arisen against me, and the kind which are harshest and gravest; 23a
as a result, many slanders have arisen from them, and I got this
name of being "wise." For those present on each occasion sup-
pose that I myself am wise in the things about which I refute
someone else. But it is likely, men, that really the god is wise,
and that in this oracle he is saying that human wisdom is worth
little or nothing. And he appears to say this of Socrates, and to
use my name, in order to make me an example, as if he would b
say, "That one of you, O human beings, is wisest, who, like
Socrates, knows that in truth he is worth nothing with respect to
wisdom."

So even now I still go around seeking these things and inves-
tigating in accordance with the god whomever among the

23b townsmen and foreigners I suppose to be wise. And whenever someone does not seem so to me, I come to the god's aid and show that he is not wise. And because of this occupation, I have had no leisure worth speaking of, either to do any of the things of the city or any of my own things.[53] Instead, I am in ten-
c thousandfold poverty because of my service to the god.

In addition to these things, the young who follow me of their own accord—those who have the most leisure, the sons of the wealthiest—enjoy hearing human beings examined. And they themselves often imitate me, and in turn they try to examine others. And then, I suppose, they discover a great abundance of human beings who suppose they know something, but know little or nothing. Thereupon, those examined by them are angry
d at me, not at themselves, and they say that Socrates is someone most disgusting and that he corrupts the young. And whenever someone asks them, "By doing what and teaching what?" they have nothing to say, but are ignorant. So in order not to seem to be at a loss, they say the things that are ready at hand against all who philosophize: "the things aloft and under the earth" and "not believing in gods" and "making the weaker speech the stronger." For I do not suppose they would be willing to speak the truth, that it becomes manifest that they pretend to know, but know nothing. So since they are, I suppose, ambitious and
e vehement and many, and since they speak about me in a well-ordered[54] and persuasive way, they have beaten it into your ears, slandering me vehemently for a long time.

From among these men,[55] Meletus attacked me, and Anytus and Lycon,[56] Meletus being vexed on behalf of the poets, Anytus on behalf of the craftsmen and the politicians, and
24a Lycon on behalf of the orators. Therefore, as I said when I began, I would be amazed if I should be able to remove this prejudice of yours in such a short time, now that it has become so great. This is the truth for you, men of Athens; I am hiding nothing from you either great or small in my speech, nor am I holding anything back. And yet I all but know that I incur hatred by these very things; which is also a proof that I speak the truth, and that this is the prejudice against me, and that these are its
b causes. Whether you investigate these things now or later, you will discover that this is so.

So about the things which the first accusers accused me of, let this be a sufficient defense speech before you. But against Meletus, the "good and patriotic,"[57] as he asserts, and the later accusers, I will try to speak next in my defense. Now again, just as though these are other accusers, let us take up their sworn statement. It is something like this: it asserts that Socrates does injustice by corrupting the young, and by not believing in the gods in whom the city believes, but in other *daimonia*[58] that are new. The charge is of this sort.[59] But let us examine each part of this charge. 24b c

Now he asserts that I do injustice by corrupting the young. But I, men of Athens, assert that Meletus does injustice, because he jests in a serious matter, easily bringing human beings to trial, pretending to be serious and concerned about things for which he never cared[60] at all. That this is so, I will try to display to you as well.

Now come here, Meletus, tell me: do you not regard it as a matter of the highest importance, how the youth will be the best possible? d

[MELETUS] I do.

[SOCRATES] Then come now and tell these men: Who makes them better? It is clear that you know, since you care, at least. For since you have discovered the one who corrupts them, as you assert, you are bringing me before these men and accusing me. But come, tell them and inform them who it is who makes them better.

Do you see, Meletus, that you are silent and have nothing to say? And yet does it not seem shameful to you, and a sufficient proof of what I say, that you have never cared? But say, my good man, who makes them better?

[MELETUS] The laws.

[SOCRATES] But I am not asking this, best of men, but what human being is it who knows first of all this very thing, the laws? e

[MELETUS] These men, Socrates, the judges.

[SOCRATES] What are you saying, Meletus? Are these men here able to educate the young, and do they make them better?

[MELETUS] Very much so.

[SOCRATES] All of them, or some of them, and some not?

24e [MELETUS] All of them.

[SOCRATES] Well said, by Hera,[61] for you speak of a great abundance of helpers. What, then? Does the audience[62] here
25a make them better or not?

[MELETUS] These too.

[SOCRATES] And what about the Councilmen?[63]

[MELETUS] The Councilmen too.

[SOCRATES] But then, Meletus, surely those in the Assembly,[64] the Assemblymen, do not corrupt the youth? Or do all those too make them better?

[MELETUS] Those too.

[SOCRATES] Then all the Athenians, as it appears, make them noble and good except me, and I alone corrupt them. Is this what you are saying?

[MELETUS] I do say these things, most vehemently.

[SOCRATES] You have charged me with much misfortune. Now answer me. Does it seem to you to be so also concerning
b horses? Do all human beings make them better, while a certain one is the corrupter? Or is it wholly opposite to this, that a certain one is able to make them better—or very few, those skilled with horses—while the many, if they ever associate with horses and use them, corrupt them? Is this not so, Meletus, both concerning horses, and all the other animals?

Of course it is, in every way, whether you and Anytus deny or affirm it. For it would be a great happiness for the young if one alone corrupts them, while the others help them. But in fact,
c Meletus, you have sufficiently displayed that you never thought about the young. And your own lack of care is clearly apparent, in that you have cared nothing about the things for which you bring me in here.

But tell us next, Meletus, before Zeus, whether it is better to dwell among upright citizens or villainous ones?

Sir, answer. For surely I am asking nothing hard. Do not the villainous do something bad to whoever are nearest to them, while the good do something good?

[MELETUS] Certainly.

d [SOCRATES] Is there anyone, then, who wishes to be harmed by those he associates with, rather than to be helped?

Answer, my good man. For the law orders you to answer. Is there anyone who wishes to be harmed? 25d

[MELETUS] Of course not.

[SOCRATES] Come then, do you bring me in here saying that I voluntarily corrupt the young and make them more villainous, or involuntarily?

[MELETUS] Voluntarily, I say.

[SOCRATES] What then, Meletus? Are you so much wiser at your age than I at mine, that you know that the bad always do something bad to those who are closest to them, and the good do something good; whereas I have come into so much ignorance, that I do not even know that if I ever do something wretched to one of my associates, I will risk getting back something bad from him? So that I do so much bad voluntarily, as you assert? Of this I am not convinced by you, Meletus, nor, do I suppose, is any other human being. But either I do not corrupt, or if I do corrupt, I do it involuntarily, so in both cases what you say is false. e 26a

And if I corrupt involuntarily, the law is not that you bring me in here for such involuntary mistakes, but that you take me aside in private to teach and admonish me. For it is clear that if I learn, I will stop doing what I do involuntarily. But you avoided associating with me and teaching me, and you were not willing to, but instead you brought me in here, where the law is to bring in those in need of punishment, not learning.

But in fact, men of Athens, what I said is already clear, that Meletus never cared about these things either much or little. Nevertheless, speak to us, how do you assert that I corrupt the youth, Meletus? Or is it clear, according to the indictment that you wrote, that it is by teaching them not to believe in the gods in whom the city believes, but in other *daimonia* that are new? Do you not say that it is by teaching this that I corrupt them? b

[MELETUS] I certainly do say this, most vehemently.

[SOCRATES] Then before these very gods, Meletus, about whom our speech now is, speak to me and to these men yet more clearly. For I am not able to understand[65] you: are you saying that I teach them to believe that there are some gods—and I myself, then, believe that there are gods, and I am not c

26c completely godless, nor do I do injustice in this way—although I do not believe in those in whom the city believes, but in others, and this is what you charge me with, that I believe in others? Or do you assert that I myself do not believe in gods at all, and that I teach this to others?

[MELETUS] This is what I say, that you do not believe in gods at all.

d [SOCRATES] Meletus, you amazing man, why do you say this? Do I not even believe, then, that sun and moon are gods, as other human beings do?

[MELETUS] No, by Zeus, judges,[66] since he declares that the sun is stone and the moon is earth.

[SOCRATES] Do you suppose you are accusing Anaxagoras,[67] my dear Meletus? And do you so much despise these men here and suppose that they are so inexperienced in letters, that they do not know that the books of Anaxagoras of Clazomenae are full of these speeches? Moreover, do the young learn these things from me, when it is sometimes possible for them to buy
e them in the orchestra for a drachma,[68] if the price is high, and to laugh at Socrates if he pretends that they are his own, especially since they are so strange? But before Zeus, is this how I seem to you? Do I believe there is no god?

[MELETUS] You certainly do not, by Zeus, not in any way at all.

[SOCRATES] You are unbelievable, Meletus, even, as you seem to me, to yourself. This man seems to me, men of Athens, to be very insolent and unrestrained, and simply to have written this indictment with a certain insolence[69] and unrestraint and youth-
27a ful rashness. He is just like someone putting together a riddle and testing me: "Will Socrates the 'wise' recognize that I am joking and contradicting myself, or will I deceive him and the rest of the listeners?" For this man appears to me to be contradicting himself in the indictment, as if he were saying, "Socrates does injustice by not believing in gods, but believing in gods." And yet this is playfulness.

Now consider with me, men, how he appears to me to say this. And you answer us, Meletus. But you others, as I begged
b of you from the beginning, remember not to make a disturbance against me if I make the speeches in my accustomed way.

Is there any human being, Meletus, who believes that there 27b
are human matters,[70] but does not believe in human beings?

Let him answer, men, and let him not keep on making disturbances one after another. Is there anyone who does not believe in horses, but believes in horse-matters? Or anyone who does not believe in flute-players, but believes in flute-matters?

There is not, best of men. If you do not wish to answer, I say it for you and for these others. But at least answer what comes next. Is there anyone who believes that there are daimonic matters, but does not believe in daimons? c

[MELETUS] There is not.

[SOCRATES] How you gratify me by answering reluctantly when compelled by these men! Now then, you assert that I believe in and teach *daimonia*; and whether they are new or ancient, at any rate I do believe in *daimonia* according to your speech, and you also swore to this in the indictment. But if I believe in *daimonia*, then surely there is also a great necessity that I believe in daimons. Is this not so?

Of course it is. I set you down as agreeing, since you do not answer. And do we not believe that daimons are either gods or d
children of gods? Do you affirm this or not?

[MELETUS] Certainly.

[SOCRATES] Therefore if I believe in daimons, as you assert, and if, on the one hand, daimons are certain gods, then this would be what I assert that you are riddling and joking about, when you assert that I do not believe in gods, and again that I believe in gods, since I do believe in daimons.

On the other hand, if daimons are certain bastard children of gods, whether from nymphs or from certain others of whom it is also said they are born,[71] then what human being would believe that there are children of gods, but not gods? It would be just as strange if someone believed in children of horses e
or asses—mules—but did not believe that there are horses and asses.[72] But, Meletus, there is no way that you did not write this indictment either to test us in these things, or else because you were at a loss about what true injustice you might charge me with. There is no device by which you could persuade any human being who is even slightly intelligent, that the same man believes in both *daimonia* and divine things,



27e but that this same man believes in neither daimons nor gods
28a nor heroes.[73]

But in fact, men of Athens, that I do not do injustice according to Meletus' indictment, does not seem to me to need much of a defense speech, but even these things are sufficient. What I also said earlier—that much hatred has arisen, and among many men—know well that this is true. And this is what will convict me, if it does convict me: not Meletus or Anytus, but the prejudice and envy of the many. This has convicted many others, and
b good men too, and I suppose it will also convict me. And there is no danger that it will stop with me.

Perhaps, then, someone might say, "Then are you not ashamed, Socrates, of having followed the sort of pursuit from which you now run the risk of dying?"

I would respond to him with a just speech:[74] "What you say is not noble, you human being,[75] if you suppose that a man who is of even slight worth should take into account the danger of living or dying, but not rather consider this alone whenever he acts: whether his actions are just or unjust, and the deeds of a
c good man or a bad. For according to your speech, those of the demigods who died at Troy would be paltry, both the others and the son of Thetis.[76] Rather than endure anything shameful, he despised danger so much, that when his mother (a goddess) spoke to him as he was eager[77] to kill Hector, it was something like this, as I suppose: 'Son, if you avenge the murder of your comrade Patroclus and kill Hector, you yourself will die; for directly,' she declares, 'after Hector, your fate is ready at hand.' But when he heard this, he belittled death and danger, for he
d feared much more to live as a bad man and not to avenge his friends. 'Directly,' he declares, 'may I die, after I inflict a penalty[78] on the one doing injustice, so that I do not remain here ridiculous beside the curved ships, a burden on the land.' Surely you do not suppose that he thought about death and danger?"[79]

This is the way it is, men of Athens, in truth. Wherever someone stations himself, holding that it is best, or wherever he is stationed by a ruler,[80] there he must remain and run the risk, as it seems to me, and not take into account death or anything else before what is shameful. So I would have done terrible
e deeds, men of Athens, if, when the rulers whom you chose to

rule me stationed me in Potideia and Amphipolis and at Delium,[81] I remained where they stationed me and ran the risk of dying like anyone else, but when the god stationed me, as I supposed and assumed, ordering me to live philosophizing and examining myself and others, I had left my station because I feared death or anything else whatever. 28e 29a

That would be terrible, and truly then someone might justly bring me into a law court; then he might say that I do not believe in gods, since I would be disobeying the divination, and fearing death, and supposing that I am wise when I am not. For to fear death, men, is nothing other than to seem to be wise, but not to be so. For it is to seem to know what one does not know: no one knows whether death does not happen to be the greatest of all goods for the human being; but they fear it[82] as though they knew well that it is the greatest of evils. How is this not that b reproachable ignorance of supposing that one knows what one does not know? But, men, perhaps I am distinguished from the many human beings also here in this, and if I were to declare myself wiser than anyone in anything, it would be in this: that since I do not know sufficiently about the things in Hades,[83] so also I do not suppose I know. But I do know that it is bad and shameful to do injustice and to disobey one's better, whether god or human being. So rather than do the bad things which I know are bad, I will never fear nor flee the things about which I do not know whether they happen to be good.[84]

So if you let me go now, and if you disobey Anytus—who said c that either I should not have been brought in here at the beginning, or, since I was brought in, that it is not possible not to kill[85] me (he asserted before you that if I am acquitted, soon your sons, pursuing what Socrates teaches, will all be completely corrupted)—if you would say to me with regard to this, "Socrates, for now we will not obey Anytus; we will let you go, but on this condition: that you no longer spend time in this investigation nor philosophize; and if you are caught still doing this, d you will die"—if you would let me go, then, as I said, on these conditions, I would say to you, "I salute you and cherish you, men of Athens, but I will obey the god rather than you; and as long as I breathe and am able to, I will not stop philosophizing, and I will exhort you and explain this to whomever of you I

29d happen upon, and I will speak just the sorts of things I am accustomed to: 'Best of men, you who are an Athenian, from the city that is greatest and best reputed for wisdom and strength, are you not ashamed that you care for having as much money as
e possible, and reputation, and honor, but that you neither care nor think about prudence, and truth, and how your soul will be the best possible?' And if one of you disputes it and asserts that he does care, I will not immediately let him go, nor will I go away, but I will speak to him, and examine and test him. And if he does not seem to me to possess virtue, but only says that he
30a does, I will reproach him, saying that he regards the things worth the most as the least important, and the paltrier things as more important. I will do this to whomever, younger or older, I happen upon, both foreigner and townsman, but especially to the townsmen, since you are closer to me in kin.

"Know well, then, that the god orders this. And I suppose that until now no greater good has arisen for you in the city than my service to the god. For I go about and do nothing but persuade you, both younger and older, not to care about bodies and
b money before you care just as vehemently about how your soul will be the best possible. I say: 'Not from money does virtue come, but from virtue comes money and all of the other good things for human beings in both private and public life.' If, then, I corrupt the young by saying these things, they may be harmful. But if someone asserts that what I say is other than this, he speaks nonsense. With a view to these things," I would declare, "men of Athens, either obey Anytus or not, and either let me go
c or not, since I would not do otherwise, not even if I were going to die many times."

Do not make a disturbance, men of Athens, but abide by what I begged of you, not to make a disturbance at the things I say, but to listen. For, as I suppose, you will be benefited by listening. I am going to tell you certain other things at which you will perhaps cry out; but do not do this. Know well that if you kill me, since I am the sort of man that I say I am, you will not harm me more than yourselves. For Meletus or Anytus would not harm me—he would not even be able to—since I do not suppose
d it is lawful[86] for a better man to be harmed by a worse. Perhaps, however, he might kill or banish or dishonor[87] me. But this

man, and someone else, no doubt, perhaps suppose that these 30d
are great evils. I do not suppose these are, but rather doing what
this man here is now doing—trying to kill a man unjustly.

So, men of Athens, I am now far from making a defense speech on my own behalf, as someone might suppose. I do it rather on your behalf, so that you do not make a mistake about the gift of the god to you, by voting to condemn me. For if you e
kill me, you will not easily discover another like me, who—even if it is rather ridiculous to say—has simply been set upon the city by the god, as though upon a great and well-bred[88] horse who is rather sluggish because of his size and needs to be awakened by some gadfly. The god seems to me to have set me upon the city as someone of this sort: I awaken and persuade and reproach each one of you, and I do not stop settling down everywhere 31a
upon you the whole day. Someone else of this sort will not easily arise for you, men. So if you obey me, you will spare me. But perhaps you are vexed, like the drowsy when they are awakened, and if you obey Anytus and slap me, you might easily kill me. Then you would spend the rest of your lives asleep, unless the god sends you someone else in his concern for you.

That I do happen to be someone of this sort, given to the city by the god, you might think about from this: it does not seem b
human,[89] first, that I have been careless of all my own things and that for so many years now I have endured that the things of my household[90] are uncared for; and next, that I always mind your business, by going to each of you privately, as a father or an older brother might do, and persuading you to care for virtue. If I was getting something from this, and if I was receiving pay while I exhorted you to these things, it would be somewhat reasonable. But now, even you yourselves see that the accusers, who accused me so shamelessly in everything else, have not been able in this to become so utterly shameless as to offer a witness to assert that I ever took any pay or asked for it. c
For, I suppose, I offer a sufficient witness that I speak the truth—my poverty.

Perhaps, then, it might seem to be strange that I go around counseling these things and being a busybody in private, but that in public I do not dare to go up before your multitude to

31c counsel the city. The cause of this is what you have heard me speak of many times and in many places, that something divine
d and daimonic[91] comes to me, a voice—which, in fact, is what Meletus wrote into the indictment, making a comedy over it. This is something which began for me in childhood; a certain voice comes, and whenever it comes, it always turns me away from whatever I am about to do, but never urges me forward.

This is what opposes my political activity, and its opposition seems to me altogether fine. For know well, men of Athens, if I had long ago tried to be politically active, I would long ago have perished, and I would have helped neither you nor myself. And
e do not be vexed with me when I speak the truth. For no human being will preserve his life if he genuinely opposes either you or any other multitude and prevents many unjust and unlawful
32a things from happening in the city. If the man really fighting for justice is going to preserve himself even for a short time, it is necessary for him to lead a private rather than a public life.

I will offer great proofs of these things for you—not speeches, but what *you* honor, deeds. Listen, then, to what happened to me, so that you may see that I would not yield even to one man against justice because of my fear of death, even if I were to perish by refusing to yield. I will tell you vulgar things, typical of the law courts, but true. I, men of Athens, never held any other
b office in the city except for being once on the Council. And it happened that our tribe (Antiochis) held the prytany[92] when you wished to judge the ten generals (the ones who did not pick up the men from the naval battle) as a group—contrary to law, as it seemed to all of you in the time afterwards. I alone of the prytanes opposed your doing anything against the laws then, and I voted against it. And although the orators were ready to indict me and arrest me, and you were ordering and shouting, I
c supposed that I should run the risk on the side of the law and justice rather than go along with you because of fear of prison or death, when you were counseling injustice.[93]

Now this was when the city was still under a democracy. But again, when the oligarchy came to be, the Thirty summoned myself and four others into the Tholos,[94] and they ordered us to arrest Leon the Salaminian and bring him from Salamis to die.[95] They ordered many others to do things of this sort, wishing that as many as possible would be implicated in the responsibility.

Then, however, I showed again, not in speech but in deed, that I 32d
do not care about death in any way at all—if it is not too crude to
say so—but that my only care is to commit no unjust or impious
deed. That rule, as strong as it was, did not shock me into doing
anything unjust. When we came out of the Tholos, the other
four went to Salamis and arrested Leon, but I departed and
went home. And perhaps I would have died because of this, if
that rule had not been quickly dissolved. And you will have
many witnesses of these things.

Do you suppose, then, that I could have survived so many e
years if I had been publicly active and had acted in a way worthy
of a good man, coming to the aid of the just things and, as one
ought, regarding this as most important? Far from it, men of
Athens; nor could any other human being.

But through all my life, if I was ever active in public, it was 33a
apparent that I was the sort of man (and in private I was the
same) who never conceded anything to anyone contrary to
justice—neither to anyone else, nor to any of those who my
slanderers declare to be my students.[96] I never became anyone's
teacher; but if anyone, whether younger or older, ever desired
to hear me speaking and minding my own business, I never
begrudged it to anyone. And I do not converse only when I
receive money, and not when I do not receive it. On the con- b
trary, I offer myself for questioning to rich and poor alike, and if
anyone wishes to answer, he may hear what I say. And whether
any of these becomes an upright man or not, I would not justly
be held responsible, since I never promised or taught any
instruction[97] to any of them. If someone asserts that he ever
learned anything from me or heard privately what everyone else
did not, know well that he does not speak the truth. But why,
then, do certain ones enjoy spending so much time with me?
You have heard it, men of Athens, I told you the whole truth. It c
is because they enjoy hearing men examined who suppose they
are wise, but are not. For it is not unpleasant.

I have been ordered to practice this, as I affirm, by the god,
through divinations, and through dreams, and in every way
that any divine allotment ever ordered a human being to prac-
tice anything at all. These things, men of Athens, are both true
and easy to test.[98]

Now if I am corrupting some of the young, and have already d



33d corrupted others, and if any of them, when they became older, recognized that I ever counseled them badly while they were young, then now, no doubt, they should have come forward to accuse me and take their vengeance. If they themselves were not willing to, then some of their families—fathers and brothers and their other relatives—should now have remembered it and taken their vengeance if their kinsmen had suffered harm from me.

In any event, I see many of them present here: first of all Crito
e here, of my age and deme, the father of Critobulus here; and next Lysanias the Sphettian, the father of Aeschines here; and then Antiphon the Cephisean is here, the father of Epigenes. And here are others whose brothers have spent time in this way: Theozotides' son Nicostratus, the brother of Theodotus—and Theodotus has died, so he could not beg him off—and Demodocus' son Paralus, whose brother was Theages. And here is
34a Adeimantus, son of Ariston, whose brother is Plato here, and Aeantodorus, whose brother is Apollodorus here.[99]

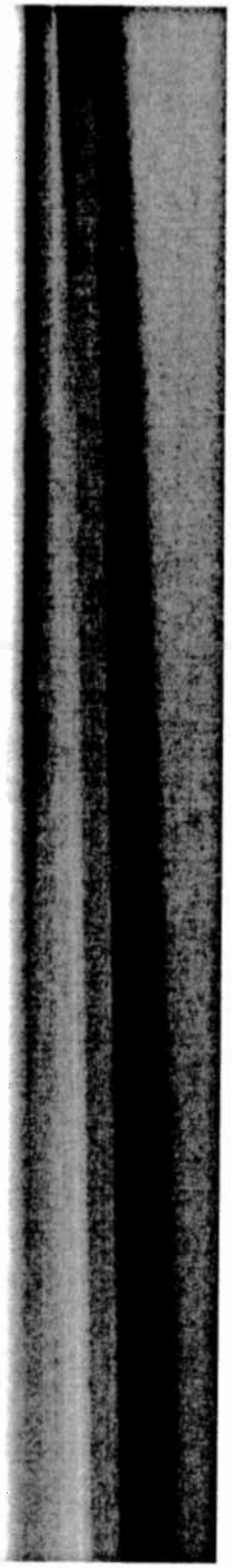
And I can tell you of many others, from among whom Meletus should certainly have offered someone as a witness during his own speech. If he forgot then, let him offer one now—I make way—and let him say if he has any such thing. But you will discover that it is wholly opposite to this, men, that everyone is ready to come to aid *me*, the corrupter, the one who does evil to their families,[100] as Meletus and Anytus assert. Now the cor-
b rupted ones themselves would perhaps have a reason to come to my aid. But the uncorrupted ones, their relatives, are now older men, so what other reason would they have to come to my aid except the correct and just one, that they know that Meletus speaks falsely, and that I am being truthful?

Well then, men. These, and perhaps other such things, are about all I would have to say in my defense. Perhaps someone
c among you may be vexed when he recalls himself, if, in contesting a trial even smaller than this trial, he begged and supplicated the judges with many tears, bringing forward his own children and many others of his family and friends, so as to be pitied as much as possible, while I will do none of these things, although in this I am risking, as I might seem, the extreme danger. Perhaps, then, someone thinking about this may be rather stub-

born toward me, and, angered by this, he may set down his vote 34c
in anger. If there is someone among you like this—for I do not d
deem that there is, but if there is—to me it seems decent for me
to say to this man, "I too, best of men, no doubt have some
family; for just as Homer has it, not even I have grown up 'from
an oak or a rock,' but from human beings."[101] So I do have a
family, and sons too, men of Athens, three of them, one already
a young man, and two still children. Nevertheless I will bring
none of them forward here in order to beg you to acquit me.

Why, then, will I do none of these things? Not because I am
stubborn, men of Athens, nor because I dishonor you. Whether e
I am daring with regard to death or not is another story;[102] but as
to reputation, mine and yours and the whole city's, to me it does
not seem to be noble for me to do any of these things. For I am
old and have this name—and whether it is true or false, it is
reputed at any rate that Socrates is distinguished from the many 35a
human beings in some way. If, then, those of you who are
reputed to be distinguished, whether in wisdom or courage or
any other virtue at all, are to act in this way, it would be shame-
ful. I have often seen some such men when they are judged,
who, although they are reputed to be something, do amazing
deeds, since they suppose that they will suffer something terri-
ble if they die—as though they would be deathless if you did not
kill them. They seem to me to attach shame to the city, so that
anyone, even a foreigner, would assume that those Athenians b
who are distinguished in virtue—the ones whom they pick out
from among themselves for their offices[103] and other honors—
are not distinguished from women. For those of you, men of
Athens, who are reputed to be something in any way at all,
should not do these things; nor, whenever we do them, should
you allow it. Instead, you should show that you would much
rather vote to convict the one who brings in these piteous
dramas and makes the city ridiculous, than the one who keeps
quiet.

Apart from reputation, men, to me it also does not seem to be
just to beg the judge, nor to be acquitted by begging; one should c
rather teach and persuade. For the judge is not seated to give the
just things away by favor, but to judge them. For he has not
sworn to favor whoever he pleases,[104] but to give judgment



35c according to the laws. Therefore we should not accustom you to swear falsely, nor should you become accustomed to it. For neither of us would be pious.

So do not deem that I, men of Athens, should practice such things before you which I hold to be neither noble nor just nor
d pious, and certainly, by Zeus, above all when I am being prosecuted for impiety by Meletus here. Clearly, if I should persuade you and force you by begging, after you have sworn an oath, I would be teaching you to hold that there are no gods, and in making my defense speech I would simply be accusing myself of not believing in gods. But that is far from being so. For I believe, men of Athens, as none of my accusers does. I turn it over to you and to the god to judge me in whatever way it will be best both for me and for you.

[*The jury votes on Socrates' innocence or guilt, and a majority finds him guilty as charged. Meletus then makes a speech proposing the death penalty, and Socrates must offer a counterproposal.*]

e I am not vexed, men of Athens, at what has happened—that
36a you voted to convict me—for many reasons, among which is that what has happened was not unexpected[105] by me. But I am much more amazed at the number of the votes on each side. For I at least did not suppose it would be by a little, but by much. Now, as it appears, if only thirty of the votes had fallen differently, I would have been acquitted. So as it seems to me, I have even now been acquitted as far as Meletus is concerned; and not only have I been acquitted, but it is clear to everyone that if Anytus (and Lycon) had not come forward to accuse me, he would have had to pay a fine of a thousand drachmae, since
b he would not have gotten a fifth of the votes.[106]

At any rate, the man proposes death as my desert.[107] Well, then. What counterproposal shall I make to you, men of Athens? Or is it not clear that it should be whatever I am worthy of? What then? What am I worthy to suffer or to pay, just because I did not keep quiet during my life and did not care for the things that the many do—money-making and management of the household, and generalships, and public oratory, and the other offices and conspiracies and the factions that come to be in

the city—because I held that I was really too decent to survive if I went into these things? I did not go into matters where, if I did go, I was going to be of no help either to you or to myself; instead, I went to each of you privately to perform the greatest benefit, as I affirm, and I tried to persuade each of you not to care for any of his own things, until he cares for himself, how he will be the best and most prudent possible, nor to care for the things of the city, until he cares for the city itself, and so to care for the other things in the same way. What, then, am I worthy to suffer, being such a man? Something good, men of Athens, if you give me what I deserve according to my worth in truth—and besides, a good of a sort that would be fitting for me. What, then, is fitting for a poor man, a benefactor, who needs to have leisure to exhort you? There is nothing more fitting, men of Athens, than for such a man to be given his meals in the prytaneum, much more so than if someone among you has won a victory at Olympia with a horse or a two- or four-horse chariot.[108] For he makes you seem to be happy, while I make you be happy; and he is not in need of sustenance, while I am in need of it. So if I must propose what I am worthy of in accordance with justice, I propose this: to be given my meals in the prytaneum.

Perhaps, then, when I say this, I seem to you to speak in nearly the same way as when I spoke about the lament and supplication—quite stubbornly. That is not so, men of Athens, but rather it is something like this: I am convinced that I do not do injustice to any human being voluntarily, but I do not persuade you of this. For we have conversed[109] with each other a short time. Since, as I suppose, if you had a law, like other peoples,[110] not to judge anyone in a matter of death in one day, but over many days, you would be persuaded. Now, however, it is not easy in a short time to do away with great prejudices.

Being convinced that I do not do injustice to anyone, I am far from doing myself an injustice, and from saying against myself that I am worthy of something bad, and from proposing this sort of thing as my desert. Fearing what? That I might suffer what Meletus proposes for me, about which I declare that I do not know whether it is good or bad? Or instead of this, should I choose to propose something from among the things which I

37b know well are bad? Should it be prison? And why should I live
c in jail, enslaved to the authority which is regularly set up there, the Eleven?[111] Or money, and imprisonment until I pay? But for me, this is the same as what I just now said, for I have no money to pay.

But then should I propose exile? For perhaps you would give this as my desert. I would certainly be possessed by excessive love of life,[112] men of Athens, if I were so unreasonable that I were not able to reckon that you, who are my fellow citizens,
d were not able to bear my ways of spending time and my speeches, but that instead, they have become quite grave and hateful to you, so that you are now seeking to get rid of them. Will others, then, bear them easily? Far from it, men of Athens. Fine, indeed, would life be for me, a human being of my age, to go into exile and to live exchanging one city for another, always being driven out. For I know well that wherever I go, the young will listen to me speaking, just as here. And if I drive them away, they themselves will drive me out by persuading their
e elders. But if I do not drive them away, their fathers and families will drive me out, for the sake of these same young men.

Perhaps, then, someone might say, "By being silent and keeping quiet, Socrates, will you not be able to live in exile for us?" It is of all things the hardest to persuade some of you about this. For if I say that this is to disobey the god, and that because of
38a this it is impossible to keep quiet, you will not believe me, since you will suppose that I am being ironic.[113] But again, if I say that this does happen to be the greatest good for a human being, to make speeches every day about virtue and the other things about which you hear me conversing and examining both myself and others, and that the unexamined life is not worth living for a human being, you will believe me even less when I say these things. This is the way it is, as I affirm, men; but to persuade you is not easy.

And at the same time, I am not accustomed to deem myself
b worthy of anything bad. If I had money, I would have proposed as much money as I could pay, for that would not harm me. But now I do not have any, unless you wish me to propose as much money as I am able to pay. Perhaps I would be able to pay you about a mina of silver.[114] So I propose that much.

But Plato here, men of Athens, and Crito and Critobulus and 38b
Apollodorus bid me to propose thirty minae,[115] and they themselves will stand surety. So I propose that much, and these men will be trustworthy sureties of the silver for you.

[*Voting between the penalties proposed by the accuser and the accused, the jury condemns Socrates to death. He has time to make some further remarks before he is taken away to prison to await execution.*]

For the sake of not much time, men of Athens, you will be c
given the name and the responsibility, by those wishing to abuse the city, for having killed Socrates, a wise man. For those wishing to reproach you will assert that I am wise, even if I am not. At any rate, if you had waited a short time, this would have come about for you of its own accord. For you see that my age is already far advanced in life and close to death. I say this not to all of you, but to those who voted to condemn me to death. d

I also say this to these same ones: Perhaps you suppose, men of Athens, that I have been convicted because I was at a loss for the sort of speeches that would have persuaded you, if I had supposed that I should do and say anything at all to escape[116] the penalty.[117] Far from it. But I have been convicted because I was at a loss, not however for speeches, but for daring and shamelessness and for not being willing to say the sorts of things to you that you would have been most pleased to hear: me wailing and lamenting, and doing and saying many other things unworthy of me, as I affirm—such things as you have e
been accustomed to hear from others. But neither did I then suppose that I should do anything slavish[118] because of the danger, nor do I now regret that I made my defense speech like this: I much prefer to die having made my defense speech like this, than to live like that.

For neither in a court case nor in war should I or anyone else devise a way to escape death by being willing to do anything at 39a
all. In battles it often becomes clear that one might escape death by letting go of his arms and turning around to supplicate his pursuers.[119] And there are many other devices to escape death in each of the dangers, if one dares to do and say anything at all. But I suppose it is not hard, men, to escape death, but it is much

39b harder to escape villainy. For it runs faster than death.[120] And now I, since I am slow and old, am caught by the slower, while my accusers, since they are clever and sharp, are caught by the faster, by evil. And now I go away, condemned by you to pay the penalty of death, but they have been convicted by the truth of wretchedness and injustice. And I abide by my penalty, and so do they. Perhaps these things had to be so, and I suppose there is due measure in them.

c After this, I desire to deliver oracles to you, O you who voted to condemn me. For I am now where human beings most of all deliver oracles—when they are about to die.[121] I declare, you men who have condemned me to death, that vengeance will come upon you right after my death, and much harsher, by Zeus, than the sort you give me by killing me. You have done this now supposing that you will be let off from giving an account of your life, but it will turn out much the opposite for you,

d as I affirm. There will be more who will put you to the test, whom I am now holding back; you did not perceive them. And they will be harsher, since they are younger, and you will be more vexed. For if you suppose that by killing human beings you will prevent someone from reproaching you for not living correctly, you do not think nobly. For to be let off is not at all possible or noble; but it is both noblest and easiest, not to restrain others, but to equip oneself to be the best possible. And so, having divined these things for you who voted against me, I take my leave.

e Yet with those who voted for me I would be pleased to converse about this matter which has happened, while the officials are occupied and I do not yet go to the place where, when I do go, I must die. But stay with me, men, for this much time; nothing prevents our telling tales[122] to one another as long as it is possible. For I am willing to show clearly to you, as to friends,

40a what this thing means which has occurred to me now. Since, judges—for by calling you judges I would address you correctly[123]—something amazing has happened to me. My customary divination from the *daimonion* was always very frequent in all the former time, opposing me even in very small matters, if I were about to do something incorrectly. Now, you yourselves see what has occurred to me, this thing which someone might

suppose and believe to be the extreme of evils. But the sign of 40a
the god did not oppose me when I left my house this morning, b
nor when I came up here to the law court, nor anywhere in the
speech when I was about to say anything. And yet in other
speeches it has often stopped me in the middle when I was
speaking. But now it has nowhere opposed me concerning this
action—not in any deed or speech. What, then, do I take to be
responsible for this? I will tell you. What has occurred to me is
likely to be good, and there is no way that we take it correctly
if we suppose that being dead is an evil. For me, a great proof c
of this has happened. For there is no way that the accustomed
sign would not have opposed me, if I were not about to do some-
thing good.

Let us also think in this way how great a hope there is that it is
good: For being dead is either of two things. Either it is such as
to be nothing and the dead man has no perception of anything,
or else, in accordance with the things that are said,[124] it happens
to be a certain change and migration of the soul from the place
here to another place.

And if there is no perception, but it is like a sleep in which the d
sleeper has no dream, death would be a marvelous gain. For I
would suppose that if someone had to select the night in which
he slept so soundly that he did not even dream, and had to
contrast the other nights and days of his own life with that night,
and then had to say on consideration how many days and nights
in his own life he had spent better and more pleasantly than that
night, I would suppose, not that some private man, but that the
Great King himself[125] would find that they are easy to count
compared with the other days and nights. If, then, death is such e
a thing, I at least say it is a gain. For all time appears thus to be
nothing more than one night.

But again, if death is something like a journey from here to
another place, and if the things that are said are true, that all the
dead are there, then what greater good could there be than this,
judges? For if someone who arrives in Hades, leaving behind 41a
those here who claim to be judges, shall find the true judges—
those who are said to give judgment there, Minos and
Rhadamanthys, and Aeacus, and Triptolemus,[126] and as many
of the other demigods who were just in their own life—would

this journey be anything paltry? Or again, to associate with Orpheus and Musaeus and Hesiod and Homer,[127] how much would any of you give? I am willing to die many times if these things are true. Since for myself, at least, spending time there would be marvelous: when I would happen upon Palamedes and Telemonian Ajax,[128] or anyone else of the ancients who has died because of an unjust judgment, I would compare my own experiences with theirs. As I suppose, it would not be unpleasant. But certainly the greatest thing is that I would pass my time examining and searching out among those there—just like those here—who among them is wise, and who supposes he is, but is not. How much would one give, judges, to examine the one who led the great army against Troy, or Odysseus, or Sisyphus,[129] or countless others whom one might mention, both men and women? To converse and to associate with them and to examine them there would be inconceivable[130] happiness. Surely those there do not kill on this account. For not only in other things are those there happier than those here: they are also deathless henceforth for the rest of time, at least if the things that are said are true.

But you too, judges, should be of good hope toward death, and you should think this one thing to be true: that there is nothing bad for a good man, whether living or dead, and that the gods are not without care for his troubles.[131] Nor have my present troubles arisen of their own accord, but it is clear to me that it was now better for me to be dead and to have left troubles behind. Because of this, the sign also nowhere turned me away, and I at least am not very vexed at those who voted to condemn me and at my accusers. And yet it was not with this thought that they voted to condemn me and accused me: they supposed they would harm me. For this they are worthy of blame.

This much, however, I beg of them: When my sons grow up, punish them, men, and pain them in the very same way I pained you, if they seem to you to care for money or anything else before virtue. And if they are reputed to be something when they are nothing, reproach them just as I did you: tell them that they do not care for the things they should, and that they suppose they are something when they are worth nothing. And if

you will do these things, we will have been treated justly by you, both I myself and my sons. 42a

But now it is time to go away, I to die and you to live. Which of us goes to a better thing is unclear to everyone except to the god.[132]